have to have both together.'

We went upstairs to the club offices. Nothing to do with the climb, but I felt a little breathless. And held Victoria's hand a little tighter. I think we must have come up the back way because we suddenly turned a corner and there we were: a corridor, heads poking out of doorways, half a dozen blokes in suits shifting from foot to foot. It looked like any suite of offices in any modern block anywhere in Europe. All very simple. Nothing grand, nothing flash. I liked that: Real saved the big impression for out on the field. I was excited to be there. I could tell, as people came up to shake hands and be introduced, that they didn't mind me knowing they were excited about it too.

José introduced me to the Director of Football, Jorge Valdano; probably the man most responsible, along with the President, for bringing me to Madrid. He had a presence about him and a great smile. I don't know how old Senor Valdano must be but he's still got the build and the energy of the international player he once was. I'd fancy my chances in a running race: I wouldn't be so keen on a tackle. He was one of the few people at the club who didn't speak any English, which was fine by me. The two of us were on an equal footing, weren't we? Senor Valdano showed me into the office he'd been standing outside. Carlos Queiroz stood up from behind the Head Coach's desk. It was a surprise to see him. I knew all about Madrid having released Vicente del Bosque. I also knew Carlos had left Manchester United to replace him, and how good Carlos was at his job. But I hadn't realized he'd be at the Bernabeu already. It was an odd moment, a reassuring moment. *Who's following who around here?* We had a hug. We'd see each other—two new boys—for pre-season at the end of July.

Right now, they were ready to show me around my office. We all trooped back downstairs, with José leading the way and doing his best official Real tour guide impression: 'And this is where the tours never go,' he said, swinging open the door to the home dressing room. On every locker door there was an image, bench to ceiling, of the Real player it belonged to. For a moment, it made me feel like an opponent again, seeing them all, almost life-sized around the walls: Raul, Figo, Ronaldo, Zidane, Roberto Carlos and their team-mates. What was it going to be like, playing alongside them instead of against them? We moved through and out into the tunnel. I could remember standing here back in April, itching to get started. It felt the same now.

'José? Is there a ball anywhere? I can't wait.'

One appeared. I gave it to Brooklyn to carry and I walked out into a